

It is true that Nelson was a consummate professional and a hard-working manager . . . but at times of decision, leaders need to make contact with foundational convictions and with a sense of calling which comes from going deep within oneself. This is the source of healthy self-confidence and the ability to master fear and to encourage people in the most extreme circumstances. Any education system which hopes to produce effective leaders and followers must take the formation of these foundational convictions very seriously.

Yet we live at a strange time when the periodic table and anything that can be quantified and reduced to a mathematical truth is regarded as an accurate description of reality, but the Beatitudes and the teachings of the world's wisdom traditions are seen as little more than the debatable opinions of dead sages.

Nelson's sense of personal and individual call was developed within a tradition which also understands growth in the spiritual life as growth in love of neighbour. Nelson spared no pains to stand by and serve his shipmates. He exhibited an infectious trust in people which called out the best in them and engaged them not only to Nelson's person but enrolled them in the cause in which he believed . . . a faith that people are to be trusted in a way that helps them to be trust-worthy.

Measure First, Judge Later?

What, then, is to be done about this apparent triumph of counting over trusting? For one good set of answers, I turn to David Boyle, English social critic and author of *The Sum of Our Discontent*.

We are . . . living at an age when life is completely overwhelmed by numbers and calculation, and we are all increasingly controlled by "targets." . . . The frightening thing is that, just because computers can count and measure nearly everything, then we do. There was a time when we could trust our own judgment, common sense, and intuition to know if we